



Timur Ruby

△ **Timur Ruby**, in the necklace made for Queen Victoria

Of the Royal Crown Jewels of Britain, there is one exceptional gem that is not what it seems, an impostor that passed through the hands of the rich and powerful for hundreds of years. Until 1851, it was the largest known ruby in the world, but at the time of its documented discovery in 1612, and for hundreds of years afterwards, no one was aware that the Timur Ruby was not a ruby at all, but a spinel.

It was only in the latter half of the 19th century that gemologists began to differentiate between the two. The mistake, however, was understandable. Rubies and spinels look almost identical, and share a similar chemical composition and hardness. What separates them is the way in which they refract light – rubies are doubly refractive, while spinels are singly

refractive. When light enters a ruby, it is split in two and each beam travels at a different speed. In contrast, when light enters a spinel only one beam of light is generated – an unusual characteristic that is also shared by diamonds and garnets.

Despite its changed classification, the Timur Ruby remains a highlight of the British Crown Jewels. It is named after the Mongol ruler who conquered Delhi in 1398, and who is believed to have taken the gem during the invasion. Returned to India in 1612, the gem was passed down through generations of Mughal emperors, each of whom inscribed their name on its surface. During Britain's annexation of India in the late 1840s, the Timur Ruby and other spinels were shipped to England and presented to Queen Victoria, who openly admired "the wonderful rubies".



Timur, one of the last great conquerors of the Eurasian steppe, pictured holding his crown

[It] is the largest in the world, therefore even more remarkable than the Koh-i-noor

Queen **Victoria**
1851

Key dates

1398–20th century

